

Ill-timed Makeover

Building a team for the future may be a great idea, but the veterans should have been forewarned

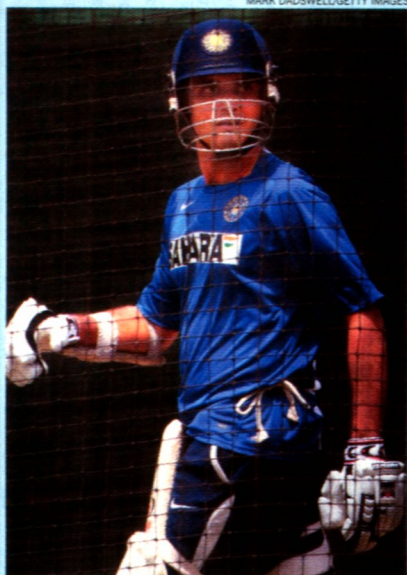
The selection of the Indian team for the month-long tri-nation limited-overs Commonwealth Bank (CB) Series has thrown into the wider public arena the dilemma that Indian selectors will face as they try to fashion a new Indian team from the old with an eye towards the 2011 World Cup. The most prominent omission in the CB Series squad was former India captain and comeback man Sourav Ganguly.

The selectors' grapevine was quick to pass the buck for Ganguly's omission on to ODI captain M. S. Dhoni stat-

ing it was he who had asked for his first captain to be benched. It is apparent that more than a few selectors agreed with Dhoni or the Bengal left-hander would have retained his place. The decision, selectors say, was made keeping Australian conditions in mind. India will be up against Australia and Sri Lanka, two excellent fielding units on large grounds that cut into a batsman's boundary-hitting ability placing a larger premium on taking twos and threes. Ganguly's lack of speed between the sticks and over the ground ruled him out.

There is much merit in forward planning and the CB Series will tell India plenty about its next generation of batsmen. Ganguly though was India's in-form man in both forms of the game. His experience during a demanding series could have been valuable. But the most unlucky cricketer in this roulette is left-arm spinner Murali Kartik, who was the Man of the Match in his last match against Australia with a career-best of 6 for 27 in October 2007. Untested leggie Piyush Chawla was picked in his place.

The selectors have done little wrong with the Test squad. If they had a fixed term plan for all the veterans for the ODIs, communicating it unequivocally to them well before the tour would have been a good idea.



MISSING: Ganguly (left) was stunned; Kartik's axing was unfair

resilient competitor. Leipus says, "A lesser person couldn't have come back from that surgery—it is the difference between a first class cricketer and a world class cricketer."

Since his return in 2001, Kumble has taken 327 wickets, bagged more than a third of his total wickets in the last four years alone. He is now No. 3 on the all-time wicket-takers' list. Between his last two tours of Australia, he has seen results for his wickets overseas, a part of six series wins outside India, three outside the subcontinent.

A first Test century was a bonus but the captaincy now seems his due—and his natural calling. At ease with his situation, Kumble does not feel rushed, "I don't think there is too little time to do things. You have to take things series by series and it is important to do things right in each game."

In Australia, Kumble may walk the streets unnoticed but he has been recognised by its wider cricketing community. He says he was personally "encouraged and surprised" by the endorsement he received after Sydney from the average Australian.

An ICC official says, "Why did people sit up? Because it was Kumble speaking—had Ponting or Graeme Smith said it no one would have taken it seriously." This usually never happens in Australia. Usually captains Down Under are the first to be targeted and crushed by their surroundings and worsening cricketing circumstances. Mike Coward, veteran cricket columnist for *The Australian* and chronicler of Indo-Australian cricket relations, does not hesitate to draw a lofty parallel from

history. "It is a big call but in terms of his impact on wider issues and the spirit of the game, the last time Australian cricket has seen a leader of Anil Kumble's stature from overseas... well, you would have to go back to Frank Worrell."

Worrell led the West Indies on a epochal tour of Australia in 1960-61, where the visitors lost 1-2 but were so popular with the crowds for the cricket they played that half a million turned up on the streets of Melbourne to say farewell as the West Indians rode in open-topped cars to a civic reception.

When the Indians finally depart they will no doubt just use the bus to the airport. But their mighty captain, on his last tour of the toughest country in cricket, will leave behind a deep footprint and a few new definitions of the true meaning of toughness. ■